

She Walked 1,400 Miles to Make Juneteenth a National Holiday -- at Age 89

From: DOGOnews Mined: 2026-06-14 5 min read

On June 19, 1865, Union soldiers marched into Galveston, Texas, and announced something that would change millions of lives: slavery was over. The news came a staggering two and a half years after President Lincoln's **Emancipation Proclamation**. Plantation owners in remote Texas had simply ignored the order, keeping 250,000 people in **bondage**. When freedom finally arrived, the formerly enslaved erupted in celebration cookouts, dances, and prayers that planted the seeds of Juneteenth. For over a century, communities kept the tradition alive, but it wasn't until 1980 that Texas became the first state to officially recognize the holiday. That wasn't enough for Opal Lee, a retired teacher from Fort Worth. In 1989, she began a **relentless** campaign to make Juneteenth a national holiday. Her most iconic effort came in 2016: at 89 years old, she led a **symbolic** walk from Fort Worth to Washington, DC. In each city along the route, she walked exactly 2.5 miles a tribute to the 2.5 years enslaved Texans waited for their freedom. Lee's **perseverance** was crucial. On June 17, 2021, President Joe Biden signed the Juneteenth National Independence Day Act into law. It was the first new **federal holiday** since Martin Luther King Jr. Day in 1983. Now 99, Lee sees Juneteenth as a unifying force. "Juneteenth is not a Black thing, and it's not a Texas thing," she says. "People all over, I don't care what nationality, we all bleed red blood." Her journey reminds us that history isn't just about the past it's shaped by people who refuse to give up.

Word Treasure

Emancipation Proclamation -- An order by President Lincoln in 1863 that said all enslaved people in Confederate states were free.

bondage -- The state of being a slave or being forced to work against your will.

relentless -- Never giving up, no matter how long it takes or how hard it gets.

perseverance -- Continuing to try even when things are difficult, over a long time.

symbolic -- Representing a bigger idea or meaning, not just the action itself.

federal holiday -- A day recognized by the national government, when many people get off work or school.

Background you need

Juneteenth commemorates a unique moment in American history: the delayed liberation of enslaved people in Texas. The Civil War had ended in April 1865, but plantation owners in remote areas kept the news secret to maintain their labor force.

It took Union troops arriving in Galveston to enforce the Emancipation Proclamation, which President Abraham Lincoln had issued in 1863 as a wartime measure to free slaves in rebel states. For decades, Black communities held cookouts, parades, and prayer services, keeping the tradition alive.

The push for national recognition gained strength in the 21st century, led by Opal Lee, a retired teacher and activist who had experienced racism firsthand as a child. Her walk to Washington, D.C. echoed the long civil rights marches of the 1960s, such as those led by Martin Luther King Jr. (the Baptist minister and nonviolent activist who fought for racial equality).

The holiday became federal law in 2021, making it the first since Martin Luther King Jr. Day (MLK Day) was established in 1983. Today, Juneteenth represents both a celebration of freedom and a reminder that justice can be delayed.

Break it down

LEAD: Union soldiers announce end of slavery in Galveston, June 19, 1865

+ CONTEXT: 2.5 years after Emancipation Proclamation, ignored by plantation owners

TRADITION: Communities celebrate Juneteenth for over a century; Texas makes it state holiday in 1980

HERO: Opal Lee, retired teacher, begins campaign for national holiday in 1989

+ ICONIC EFFORT: Symbolic walk from Fort Worth to Washington, DC, 2016 -- 2.5 miles per city

+ TRIBUTE: 2.5 miles represents the 2.5 years of delayed freedom

VICTORY: President Biden signs Juneteenth National Independence Day Act, June 17, 2021

+ SIGNIFICANCE: First new federal holiday since MLK Jr. Day in 1983

VOICE: Lee (now 99) says it's for everyone -- 'we all bleed red blood'

THEME: History is shaped by persistent people

Why it matters

Juneteenth's long journey to national recognition shows that history is not fixed -- it is continually written by those who insist on being heard. For young people, it underscores that fighting for what is right can take decades, but persistence can eventually reshape the nation's calendar and, more importantly, its memory.

Test what you remember

1. How long after the Emancipation Proclamation did enslaved people in Texas learn they were free?
 - (A) 6 months
 - (B) 1 year
 - (C) 2.5 years
 - (D) 4 years
2. Who led a symbolic walk from Fort Worth to Washington, D.C. to push for a Juneteenth national holiday?
 - (A) Opal Lee
 - (B) Martin Luther King Jr.
 - (C) Rosa Parks
 - (D) Harriet Tubman
3. When did Texas first recognize Juneteenth as a state holiday?
 - (A) 1980
 - (B) 1865
 - (C) 1989
 - (D) 2021
4. President Joe Biden signed the Juneteenth National Independence Day Act on which date?
 - (A) June 19, 2021
 - (B) June 17, 2021
 - (C) July 4, 2021
 - (D) January 1, 2021
5. What was the last new federal holiday created before Juneteenth?
 - (A) Presidents' Day
 - (B) Veterans Day
 - (C) Martin Luther King Jr. Day
 - (D) Labor Day
6. Why did Opal Lee walk exactly 2.5 miles in each city along her route?
 - (A) It was the distance she could walk each day
 - (B) It honored the 2.5 years Texans waited for freedom
 - (C) It was the number of states that had Juneteenth as a holiday
 - (D) It matched her age at the time

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: A 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **Positive:** Juneteenth honors the end of slavery and offers a unifying moment for all Americans to reflect on freedom. Opal Lee's success proves that grassroots activism can achieve monumental change, even when it takes decades.
2. **Negative / critical:** Some critics argue that making Juneteenth a federal holiday risks turning a profound struggle into a commercialized day off without addressing systemic inequalities that still exist, like the wealth gap and voting rights.
3. **Neutral / analytical:** The delay between emancipation and celebration mirrors a broader pattern in U.S. history where marginalized groups have had to fight for recognition long after their rights were supposedly granted. The holiday's addition to the federal calendar is both a symbolic victory and a complex political act.
4. **Forward-looking:** As Juneteenth becomes more widely taught in schools, future generations may have a deeper understanding of America's full history. Activists hope the holiday will spark renewed efforts to address racial injustice, while others worry it could become another Monday-sale event.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):